After Ratan's appointment, Asiaweek wrote that 'J.R.D. must have seen something of himself—bedrock values and integrity' in Ratan.

According to other attributes, like running a large organization, for instance, Mody may have been better qualified to succeed JRD, whose admiration for the steel maker was no secret. 'JRD was starry-eyed about Russi Mody' and he even gave him two international companies, Tata Limited and Tata Incorporated, registered in London and New York, respectively, Hussain comments.

But there were questions of integrity around Mody, a view shared by many in TISCO's senior management. Virtually none of Mody's contemporaries interviewed for this work attributed to him the standard of integrity and honesty that could even remotely compare with that of Ratan or JRD. Though almost none said that Mody could be accused of enriching himself financially, all were unanimous that he saw nothing wrong in leading a 'royal life' which seemed unaffordable on his salary of Rs 15,000 a month.

Virtually every year, Mody spent more than a month in Paris and enjoyed Mediterranean cruises, hosting lavish parties on board during which the best of French food and wine were served. The most damaging remarks about Mody came from Sandipan Chakravortty, former director, Materials and Marketing, Tata Steel: 'He [Mody] used Tata Steel as his own property,' he said.

An envious Nusli Wadia, when he heard about Mody's glamorous getaways, reportedly inquired about the cost. Mody promptly sent him the details and when he saw them, an astounded Wadia abandoned his quest to live life the Mody way. 'When I saw the costs, I quickly closed the file. I could not afford it,' Muthuraman remembers Wadia telling him.

Other Qualities

Ratan had some other attributes too that enhanced his suitability in JRD's eyes. One was his prodigious memory. 'He pleases and surprises me with his memory for events. He has a very good memory and in my job you have got to have a good memory,' JRD told Lala. Ratan's 'integrity, with leadership' too impressed JRD, besides his zeal, about which is said: 'He has great energy—for example for tedious flying.'